

Megan Zhao

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Second-year pre-law student at UC Santa Barbara with a policy interest in environmental planning, invasive species regulation, and native conservation. Passionate about how we can use technology and legislation to mitigate and reverse anthropogenic ecological damage. Seeking research opportunities to explore the ecological processes behind ecosystemic regulation, and to use the results of those explorations to incite legislative change.

EDUCATION

University of California, Santa Barbara (UCSB)

September 2024 - June 2028

B.S. Environmental Science || B.A. Geography || B.A. Philosophy

Minor: Legal Humanities

- **GPA: 3.94/4.0**

RELEVANT COURSEWORK (UCSB)

- **CHEM 2A-BL:** Conducted various experiments to better understand General Chemistry concepts and practice proper chemistry lab technique. Involved organic compound synthesis and extraction, spectroscopy and spectrometer use, and data recording and analysis.
- **MCDB 1LL:** Conducted various experiments to better understand MCDB concepts and practice proper lab technique. Explored DNA behavior, genetics, and hormones. Practiced gel loading, proper pipette technique, and handling of model organisms.
- **EEMB 2LL:** Explored a variety of systems to better understand Ecology and Evolution in a lab context. Traced phylogenetic trees, prepared loading gels, used both compound and dissecting microscopes, and handled various plant, animal, and bacterial models.
- **ENVS 193DS:** Used RStudio to explain and qualify numerical and categorical environmental data and observations. Created concise graphs and reports, developed workable hypotheses and conclusions, and applied these practices in everyday life via a personal data tracking assignment.
- **GEOG 108:** Used ArcGIS to explore various trends within urban geographic settings. Learned about human population history and the development of urbanized civilizations. Explored transport and industrialization developments over time, and their subsequent impacts on population trends through map creation via ArcGIS.
- **ENVS 125A-C:** Explored the laws and regulations that have shaped current environmental (and non-environmental) laws and policies. Developed a better understanding of the processes behind land use and the priorities of various policies within California. Drafted and submitted comment letters, land-use plans, and EIRs.

EXPERIENCE

Lab Researcher || Los Angeles, CA

March 2023-Present

- Explored the effects of non-native species on long-established island locales. Learned about analysis and collection methods, communicated with overseas researchers about long-term ecosystem implications, and explored possible scientific solutions, using programs like Excel, Docs, and slides to organize information. Analyzed the potential impacts future environmental policies could hold on those areas, and explored how external policies in similar ecosystems have affected those various locales, using that information to develop workable solutions to these ongoing problems.

Undergraduate Research Assistant || UCSB

August 2025-Present

- Worked closely with Professor Ken Hiltner to design and workshop environmental literature materials for multiple classes of 800+ undergraduates. Analyzed text and media to formulate comprehensible subject questions for students, fostering their deeper understanding of the role historical approaches towards the environment have shaped modern environmental attitudes and discussion. Formatted resources for student accessibility and collaborated with TAs and the professor to help answer/accommodate questions if needed.

Exam Proctor || UCSB

October 2025-Present

- Administered and supervised accommodating testing environments for one-on-one to 20+ testing environments, facilitating an environment accommodating several diverse disabilities across multiple subjects. Facilitated and organized communication between professors and students, helped answer questions, and created a secure location for students to take exams. Helped manage testing documentation and testing-center data using technology like Excel, PowerPoint, and Word, while working in a front-desk monitoring position.

Private Tutor || Los Angeles, CA | Santa Barbara, CA

December 2020-Present

- Conducted one-on-one tutoring for a variety of students and media, from international virtual to local in-person. Developed personalized learning plans for each student via exploring various learning strategies, communicating target goals, and discussing/implementing methods for ultimate success. Translated prior knowledge across multiple fields (Chemistry, English, Math, Music, etc.) into digestible and explainable formats geared towards learning and understanding.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Dean's Honors (UCSB)

- Awarded for a > 3.75 GPA each quarter

2025 Barker Scholarship Recipient

- Awarded the Barker Scholarship for Environmental Internships by the Coeta and Donald Barker Foundation. This scholarship is awarded to 1-2 students every year for the exploration of various environmental fields of interest.

UCSB Letters and Science Honors Program

- Part of the UCSB L&S Honors Program, which provides students the opportunity to partake in an intimate community of researchers and professors. Requires a minimum completion of two honors experiences per year, and a > 3.5 GPA.

LANGUAGES

- **Professional:** English
- **Conversational:** Chinese

SKILLS

- **General Skills:** Critical thinking and analysis; communication and collaboration; writing and recordkeeping; adaptable and quick learner; team-oriented and positive
- **Technical Skills:** Proficiency in Excel, Word, and PowerPoint; familiarity with R and C++; familiarity with ArcGIS
- **Interests:** Music (Certificate of Merit Level 10, UCSB Orchestra and Wind Ensemble First Oboe); Environmental Law (Former Mock Trial Experience, Environmental Science Major); Climbing (UCSB Climbing Team Officer, UCSB ACC Employee); Shrews; Fishing